Comprehensive Guide to the Jain Dietary System and Prohibited Ingredients

Jain Guidance and References

This document has been prepared by compiling and verifying information from **Jain Agamas (scriptures), traditional Jain literature, various reliable Jain and scientific websites, publicly available information on food ingredients, and the guidance of various Jain Maharaj Sahebs**. Wherever necessary, information from multiple sources has been compared to present the most reliable and balanced understanding. Since opinions on certain topics may differ among different Jain sects and Acharyas, such differences have been clearly indicated wherever applicable.

ingredient	Religious Reason & Citation	Scientific Origin
Onion, Garlic, Potato, Ginger, Carrot, Radish, Beetroot, Sweet Potato, Elephant Foot Yam, and other Root Vegetables	Since these are *Anantkaya* (multi-bodied) root vegetables, uprooting them from the soil destroys the entire plant and causes harm to innumerable *Nigoda* living beings associated with it. Therefore, such root vegetables are avoided in the Jain tradition. (Jain Agamas – Anantkaya Principle)	Bulb, Root, Tuber, or Rhizome that grows underground.
Vinegar	Since it is produced through the process of fermentation by microorganisms, it is avoided or consumed with caution in some Jain traditions. There are differences of opinion regarding this among various Jain sects. (Jain Tradition – Differences according to sect)	A solution produced by the fermentation of alcohol by Acetic Acid Bacteria.
Citric Acid (E330)	There is no explicit prohibition in Jain scriptures. Its acceptability depends on its source of production, as it may be obtained naturally from fruits or produced through microbial fermentation. Therefore, different Jain sects have differing views regarding it. (Jain Tradition – Differences according to sect and production source)	Naturally found in lemons and other citrus fruits or industrially produced through fermentation by *Aspergillus niger*.
Ajinomoto (Monosodium Glutamate – E621)	There is no explicit prohibition in Jain scriptures. It is generally produced through plant-based fermentation, but its acceptance may vary according to sect and individual religious practice. (Jain Tradition – Differences according to sect)	A flavor enhancer produced through bacterial fermentation from plant-based sources such as starch, sugarcane, or molasses.
Sabudana (Tapioca Pearls)	Since it is made from root vegetables (Tapioca/Cassava), it is avoided in the Jain tradition according to the Anantkaya principle. (Jain Agamas – Anantkaya Principle)	Made from starch extracted from the underground tuber of Cassava/Tapioca (*Manihot esculenta*).
Honey, Meat, Butter, and Wine/Alcohol	In the Jain tradition, these four are described as *Mahavigai*. Considering the principles of non-violence (Ahimsa), harm	Honey – Bee-derived product; Meat – Animal-derived food; Butter – Dairy fat obtained from milk; Wine/Alcohol –

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	to living beings, and religious dietary principles, their avoidance is recommended. (Traditional Jain Literature – Mahavigai)	Alcoholic beverage produced through fermentation or distillation.
Stale Paneer	Since stale food is likely to promote the growth of microorganisms, it is avoided in the Jain tradition. (Traditional Jain Dietary Principles)	Fresh paneer made from milk becomes stale over time due to the growth of microorganisms.
Cheese	Since it is produced through fermentation and some varieties may use animal-derived rennet, its source should be verified. There are differences of opinion regarding this among various Jain traditions. (Jain Tradition – Differences according to sect and production source)	A dairy product made by coagulating and aging (fermenting) milk; some varieties use animal-derived or microbial rennet.
Fig	Fig belongs to the *Udumbara* group of fruits. In the Jain tradition, Udumbara fruits are avoided because they are believed to be associated with microscopic life forms and the symbiotic life cycle of the Fig Wasp. (Jain Agamas – Udumbara Fruits)	Fig (*Ficus carica*) is a *Syconium* type of fruit pollinated by a specialized Fig Wasp.
Poppy Seed	Since it is a multi-seeded food (containing innumerable seeds), it is avoided in the Jain tradition. (Traditional Jain Guidance)	Dried and mature seeds of the opium poppy plant (*Papaver somniferum*).
Makhana (Fox Nuts)	According to the guidance of some Jain Maharaj Sahebs, Makhana is produced in ponds or other water bodies, and considering the possibility of harm to aquatic living beings, its avoidance is recommended. (Traditional Jain Guidance – According to some Acharyas)	Seeds of *Euryale ferox*, which grow in ponds, lakes, and other water bodies.
Water Chestnut (Singhada)	According to the guidance of some Jain Maharaj Sahebs, since Water Chestnut grows in water bodies, its avoidance is recommended considering the possibility of harm to aquatic living beings. (Traditional Jain Guidance – According to some Acharyas)	Water Chestnut (*Trapa* spp.) is an aquatic fruit that grows in water bodies and is commonly known as Water Chestnut or Singhara.
Arrowroot Powder	Since it is made from Anantkaya root vegetables, it is avoided in the Jain tradition. (Jain Agamas – Anantkaya Principle)	Made from starch extracted from the underground rhizome of Arrowroot (*Maranta arundinacea*).
Chocolate, Cocoa Powder	There is no explicit prohibition in Jain scriptures. However, some Jain Maharaj Sahebs and traditions recommend avoiding them because there is a possibility of microscopic insect fragments being mixed during cocoa production and processing. (Traditional Jain Guidance – According to some Acharyas)	Food products prepared from the seeds of Cocoa (*Theobroma cacao*). During industrial processing, microscopic insect fragments may be present within regulatory limits.
Maida (Refined Wheat Flour)	There is no explicit prohibition of Maida in Jain scriptures. However, according to the guidance of some Jain Maharaj Sahebs, avoidance of Maida and fermented (Yeast/Fermentation) food products made from it is recommended. (Traditional Jain Guidance – According to some Acharyas)	Refined flour made by milling the endosperm of wheat.

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Rava (Suji / Semolina)	There is no explicit prohibition of Rava in Jain scriptures. However, according to the guidance of some Jain Maharaj Sahebs, avoiding Rava during Chaturmas and Paryushan is recommended. (Traditional Jain Guidance – According to some Acharyas)	Refined wheat product made by coarsely milling the wheat endosperm (Coarsely Milled Wheat Endosperm).
Dry Fruits	In some Jain traditions, dry fruits are avoided from Phagan Sud Chaudash to Kartak Sud Purnima, while their use is considered acceptable from Kartak Sud Purnima to Phagan Sud Purnima. (Traditional Jain Guidance)	Dried fruits and seeds of various trees, such as almonds, cashews, pistachios, walnuts, etc.
E471 (Mono & Diglycerides of Fatty Acids), E472 (Esters of Mono & Diglycerides), E422 (Glycerol/Glycerin), E570 (Fatty Acids), E627 (Disodium Guanylate)	These food additives may be produced from plant or animal-derived sources. Therefore, according to the Jain tradition, their source should be verified before use. (Traditional Jain Guidance)	Industrially produced food additives that may be prepared from vegetable oils, animal fats, or microorganism-based processes.
E1105 (Lysozyme)	Since it is generally obtained from egg white, it is avoided according to the Jain diet. (Traditional Jain Guidance)	A natural enzyme obtained from egg white.
E901 (Beeswax)	Since it is an animal-derived product produced by bees, it is avoided in the Jain tradition. (Traditional Jain Guidance)	Natural wax produced by honey bees (*Apis* spp.) in honeycombs.
E120 (Carmine/Cochineal), E441 (Gelatin), E542 (Bone Phosphate), E904 (Shellac)	Since these food additives are obtained from insects or animal-derived sources, they are avoided in the Jain tradition. (Traditional Jain Guidance)	Respectively: natural color obtained from cochineal insects, gelling agent made from animal collagen, bone phosphate obtained from animal bones, and natural resin produced by the lac insect.
E631 (Disodium Inosinate), E635 (Disodium Ribonucleotides)	These food additives may be produced from plant, microorganism-based, or animal-derived sources. Therefore, according to the Jain tradition, their source should be verified. (Traditional Jain Guidance)	Flavor enhancers that may be produced through fermentation or from animal-derived sources.
Wine, Alcohol, Beer, Rum, Whisky, Brandy, Vodka, Gin, Spirit, Food Ethanol	Since all these alcoholic beverages are produced through fermentation or distillation, they are avoided in the Jain tradition. (Traditional Jain Literature – Mahavigai)	Alcoholic substances produced through the fermentation and distillation of sugar, grains, grapes, fruits, or other plant-based sources.
Meat, Egg, Chicken, Fish, Seafood, Prawn/Shrimp, Crab, Oyster, Pork, Beef, Mutton/Lamb, Turkey	Since these are animal-derived food products, they are avoided in the Jain tradition according to the principle of Ahimsa (non-violence). (Jain Dietary Principles)	Food products obtained from animals, birds, and aquatic living beings (Animal-derived Food Products).

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